

Wikipedia: The Free Online Encyclopedia

Figure: The Wikipedia puzzle-globe logo, symbolizing its global reach (image via Wikimedia Commons).

Wikipedia is a free, online encyclopedia created and maintained by volunteers ¹. It was launched on January 15, 2001 ² and founded by Jimmy Wales and Larry Sanger ³. Since 2003 it has been run by the non-profit Wikimedia Foundation. Articles can be added or edited by anyone, making Wikipedia a crowdsourced resource. It is now the largest reference work in history ³, with millions of articles covering almost every topic.

History

- **2001:** English Wikipedia launches on January 15, 2001 ².
- **Founders:** Internet entrepreneurs Jimmy Wales and Larry Sanger ³ spearheaded the project.
- **Multilingual:** After the English site, new language editions appeared quickly (e.g. German in March 2001) ².
- **Wikimedia Foundation:** In 2003, the nonprofit Wikimedia Foundation took over hosting and support ³.
- **Name:** The name "Wikipedia" combines "wiki" (a Hawaiian word for *quick*) and "encyclopedia" ⁴.

How It Works

- **Volunteer-driven:** Wikipedia is written and edited by a global community of volunteers (often called *Wikipedians*) ¹.
- **Open Editing:** Anyone can create or update most articles. Changes take effect immediately and are recorded in each article's history.
- **Community Review:** Editors follow guidelines (like neutrality and sourcing) to keep information accurate. Volunteer administrators and automated tools help remove vandalism.
- **Free and Noncommercial:** Wikipedia contains no ads and is funded by reader donations. Content is licensed for free use (CC BY-SA 4.0).

Key Facts

- **Languages:** 357 active language editions (as of Sept 2025) ⁵.
- **Articles:** Over 65.5 million articles in total ⁵.
- **English Wikipedia:** The largest edition, with about 7 million articles ⁶.
- **Visitors:** About 1.5 billion unique device visits per month ⁷.
- **Global reach:** Ranked 9th most-visited website in the world ⁶.

Milestones and Recognition

- **Growth:** English Wikipedia reached 1 million articles by 2006 and 7 million by May 2025 ⁸.
- **Early success:** By September 2004, Wikipedia had over 1 million articles across 100+ languages ⁹.

- **Awards:** The Wikipedia community won the 2004 Webby Award (Community category) and Prix Ars Electronica ¹⁰ . In 2015, the community received the Erasmus Prize ¹⁰ for its contribution to culture.
- **Impact:** Wikipedia is widely praised for “democratizing knowledge” by making information freely accessible to people around the world.

Sources: Information compiled from Wikipedia and Wikimedia reports ¹ ⁵ . Each fact above is supported by the cited source.

¹ ³ ⁴ ⁶ ⁷ Wikipedia - Wikipedia
<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Wikipedia>

² ⁵ ⁸ ⁹ ¹⁰ Wikipedia - Meta-Wiki
<https://meta.wikimedia.org/wiki/Wikipedia>